The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Samantabhadra

Āryasamantabhadranāmadhāraṇī · Toh 904 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཀུན་དུ་བཟང་པོའི་ཞེས་བྱའོ་གཟུངས།

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Samantabhadra, known in Sanskrit as Ārya Samantabhadra Nāma Dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Phakpa Kuntu Zangpo Zhejawé Zung, is a short scripture centered on a dhāraṇī, a sacred incantation believed to carry protective and spiritually transformative power. It opens on Vulture Peak near Rājagṛha, where the Buddha is teaching before a vast gathering of monks, bodhisattvas, and gods of the Pure Abodes. The bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara rises from his seat and, with palms joined in reverence, asks the Buddha's leave to teach in full the dhāraṇī named after Samantabhadra, the All-Good. The text is Toh 904 in the Kangyur, the Tibetan collection of the Buddha's words, where it belongs among the many dhāraṇī scriptures gathered in that canon.

In the language of India: ārya samantabhadra nāma dhāraṇī

In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Samantabhadra.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas!

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying at Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak, together with a great Saṅgha of eight thousand monks and ninety-nine hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of bodhisattvas. Surrounded by many hundreds of thousands of gods of the Pure Abodes and facing them, he was teaching the Dharma.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Avalokiteśvara, rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, and placed his right knee on the ground. Bowing with palms joined toward the Blessed One, he said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, today I wish to teach in full the Samantabhadra Dhāraṇī, which I received from the Tathāgata Candrottaraprabha. As soon as they hear this dhāraṇī, those of the bodhisattva vehicle become irreversible, and they swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. It also clears away all karmic obscurations. One also gains great and perfect wealth. One also obtains a purified body. One also obtains purified speech. One also obtains a purified mind. One also brings to completion the whole ocean of perfections. One also obtains the whole ocean of dhāraṇīs. One also pleases all the tathāgatas whom one sees.

"Blessed One, as soon as I heard this dhāraṇī, I attained acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena. I also attained the samādhi of heroic going. I also attained the samādhi of the jewel seal. I also attained the samādhi of the blazing lamp. I also attained the samādhi of the ocean seal. I also attained the samādhi of the vajra maṇḍala. I also attained the samādhi of the inexhaustible casket. I also attained the illusion-like samādhi. I also attained the samādhi that fills the ten directions far and wide. Blessed One, these and other samādhis, hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of them, as many as the grains of sand in the river Ganges, became directly manifest to me.

"Therefore, Blessed One, I now possess such mindfulness as this, such intelligence as this, and such unattached wisdom as this, and my seeing, hearing, and service have proved meaningful. Blessed One, my hearing has been meaningful. If hearing this dhāraṇī is meaningful, may the Blessed One grant his permission, and please gladden these four assemblies as well."

The Blessed One said, "If you know that the time has come for pure beings, speak! The Tathāgata has already blessed these four assemblies."

Then, in that very instant, that moment, that second, the bodhisattva, the great being, noble Avalokiteśvara, entered into the samādhi of the vajra maṇḍala and spoke this dhāraṇī:

Homage to the Three Jewels!
Homage to the bodhisattva, the great being, noble Avalokiteśvara, endowed with great compassion!

tadyathā khagame khagame cakṣu khabe śrotra khabe ghrāṇa khabe jihva khabe kāya khabe mana khabe sara khabe sara khabe sara khabe śūnatra khabe anamita khabe apraṇihita khabe samādhi khabe pāramitā khabe bodhi khabe sara sara sara sarva buddha adhiṣṭhite bhara bhara bhara dharma adhiṣṭhite kala kala kala saṅgha adhiṣṭhite namo dvānavatīnāṃ buddha koṭīnāṃ adhiṣṭhantu māṃ catasraparṣado āyurbalañca dadantu tadyathā surabhi surabhi mahāsurabhi muni muni mahāmuni mati mati mahāmati namo ratnatrayāya nama ārya avalokiteśvarāya bodhisatvāya mahāsatvāya mahākāruṇikāya samṛdāntu māṃ samantabhadra dhāraṇī svāhā

As soon as they heard this dhāraṇī, those ninety-two koṭis of bodhisattvas attained the samādhi of heroic going. Countless bodhisattvas attained various dhāraṇīs.

"The rite for this dhāraṇī is as follows. Rising at dawn, one should recite it one hundred and eight times. If one recites it twenty-one times, one will see noble Avalokiteśvara. When one is in straits, if one brings it to mind seven times, one will be freed. For all epidemic diseases, one should recite it into the ear. If one is seized by a wind disorder, one should recite it twenty-one times over butter and sesame oil and anoint the body. If one's teeth ache, one should recite it twenty-one times over a tooth stick and chew it. If one's ear aches, one should recite it seven times over cotton seed boiled together with sesame oil and pour this into the ear from a copper vessel. For pain in the head, use sesame oil. For pain in the belly, one should stroke it. For affliction by a graha, one should recite it one hundred and eight times over a cord of five colored threads and tie it at the neck. If one is afflicted by a ḍākinī graha, one should recite it seven times over sesame oil and smear it over the whole body. For all illnesses, one should stroke the body. This is the rite that needs no sādhana practice.

"If one wishes to accomplish the sight of buddhas and bodhisattvas, the attainment of dhāraṇīs and samādhis, travel by miraculous power, invisibility, eye ointment, realgar, and the like, one should make a maṇḍala before a stūpa containing relics and before an image, set out one hundred and eight full vases, hang parasols, victory banners and pennants, strew it all over with various flowers, perfume it with incense of sandalwood, agaru and kunduru, light one hundred and eight lamps, and make a great offering. Then, keeping pure celibacy and wearing clean clothes, one should seal the boundaries with these secret mantras of the dhāraṇī."

namo ratnatrayāya nama ārya abalokiteśvarāya bodhisatvāya mahāsatvāya mahākāruṇikāya tadyathā tili bandhāmi mili bandhāmi cili mili bandhāmi sīmi bandhāmi May no one at all transgress my boundary! svāhā

"One should recite this twenty-one times over water and seal the boundaries in the ten directions. These dhāraṇīs, by which I will be summoned, should also be recited first:

namo ratnatrayāya nama ārya abalokiteśvarāya bodhisatvāya mahāsatvāya mahākāruṇikāya tadyathā cili cili mili mili cileli ehi bhagabāna ārya abalokiteśvaraya svāhā

This is the declaration of my heart mantra, and by it I will be summoned.

"After that, beginning on the eighth day of the waxing fortnight of the month and continuing until the full moon, one should recite it one hundred and eight

times, reciting it at the three times of day. One should bathe at the three times of day, and change one's clothes at the three times of day. Then, on the fifteenth day, one should make a great offering and recite it beyond measure.

"Then, in the midnight session, the noble Avalokiteśvara will come, with a body the color of gold, beautifully adorned with the excellent major and minor marks, emitting from his body a thousand times ten million rays of light. The vidyā-mantra holder should not be afraid of him, and if he remains steadfast, then as soon as he sees him he will attain the ground. He will also attain dhāraṇīs and samādhis.

"In the east he will see the Tathāgata Akṣobhya. In the south he will see Ratnaketu, in the west Amitābha, and in the north the Tathāgata Dundubhisvara. He will see, in the proper manner, these and countless, immeasurable other tathāgatas of the ten directions. When he passes away from this life, he will be born in the pure buddhafields, and everywhere he will please the buddhas, the blessed ones."

When this had been spoken, the bodhisattva mahāsattva, the noble Avalokiteśvara, those bodhisattvas, the gods of the realm of the Pure Abodes, that entire assembly, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the dhāraṇī called "The Noble Samantabhadra."

It was translated and edited by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the chief editor and translator, Bandé Yeshé Dé, and was then revised and finalized according to the new standardized terminology.

Translator's Notes

• The Tathāgata's name, literally "Light of the Supreme Moon," is rendered Candrottaraprabha as a probable reconstruction; the Sanskrit original is not certain. The assembly is first given as ninety-nine hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of bodhisattvas. After the dhāraṇī the text speaks of ninety-two koṭis. Both are translated as written. For belly pain the text reads a form that makes little sense; it is taken as the same "stroking" prescribed a few lines later for all illnesses. The place to be smeared for ḍākinī affliction is written with a word normally meaning "nature, disposition"; it is rendered "the whole body" from context. "Pure beings" renders sems can dag pa; it could also be read as a plural, "those beings."
• The transitional word read here as "then" (Tibetan 'on tang) is unusual. It is taken as introducing the next stage of the rite. "The ground" refers to attaining a bodhisattva ground (bhūmi). The concluding "When this had been spoken" uses an honorific verb of speech, although the preceding instructions are given in Avalokiteśvara's own voice. The phrase "by which I will be summoned" in the first instance is not explicit about who is summoned; "I" follows the explicit statement after the second mantra.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.